

EG United States: Democrats' Tea Party moment will drag the party left

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United States

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Democrats' Tea Party moment will drag the party left

Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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- * Progressives are on the upswing in the Democratic Party after defeating moderate incumbents in a series of primary contests, reflecting an emerging generational shift in the party's center of gravity.
 - * The Democratic Socialist wave is both larger and probably more durable than a similar surge in 2018, and it will likely drive Democrats to the left on a number of policy issues—such as Israel, AI, and tax policy—over the next two years.
 - * An emboldened far-left wing will be a force to contend with in the party, making life more difficult for Representative Hakeem Jeffries (D-NY), the presumptive next House speaker if Democrats flip the chamber, and likely pulling many 2028 presidential candidates leftward during the primaries.
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The left is leading a not-so-quiet revolution within the Democratic Party. The past two months have seen a string of notable defeats of congressional incumbents across the country. In New York, three Democratic incumbents lost their seats to left-wing challengers, with similar results in Colorado the following week. This has come after left-wing successes in mayoral races in major coastal cities, in Maine's Senate race, and in congressional primaries in California and Maine.

The scale is beyond what happened in 2018, when "The Squad"—a small group of young progressives—entered Congress by replacing longtime incumbents. Meanwhile, the independent Democratic Socialists of America (DSA) organization has doubled in size over the past 18 months, reaching 100,000 members.

This trend is largely the result of generational change: A much greater proportion of Millennial and Gen Z Democrats identify as "very liberal" than do older voters, who are gradually aging out of the electorate (see charts below). This mechanically increases the share of Democratic voters who identify as "very

liberal,” with self-identified moderates fading as a share of the party.

Michigan’s Senate primary in August is the next watchpoint. The field has consolidated to a two-candidate contest between progressive Abdul El-Sayed and moderate Representative Haley Stevens; if the Bernie Sanders-backed El-Sayed can defeat the Chuck Schumer-backed Stevens, it would be the strongest indication yet of progressive tailwinds.

On policy, the progressive wave will likely drive Democrats to the left. Recent history is instructive. The Squad had an outsize impact on the policy landscape: Proposals for a Green New Deal led indirectly to the 2022 Inflation Reduction Act; pressure from the left forced former president Joe Biden’s administration to embrace student-debt cancellation; and the slogans “defund the police” and “abolish ICE” played major roles in the 2020 and 2024 campaigns.

The DSA-aligned faction will be particularly influential on Israel—criticism of Israel and US aid for the country is the driving force of the movement—and data centers, with many on the left advocating for a moratorium. The divide on Israel is already playing out: The House Democratic caucus broke nearly evenly on a vote to block military aid to Israel on 15 July, with a highly unusual divide among members of leadership.

More broadly, the presence of a growing and influential activist group, both on the ground and in Congress, will make it harder to execute the centrist turn—especially on social and cultural issues—that many moderate Democrats believe is necessary to reclaim the White House in 2028. Former vice president Kamala Harris’s recent meetings with key far-left figures suggest that many 2028 contenders may come to think a leftward move will prove more beneficial now than it did for much of the Democratic field in 2020.

The left’s rise will make life more difficult for Jeffries as House speaker. With a small majority, Jeffries would likely need to make concessions to the far-left faction to become speaker at all. The group—owing him no particular allegiance—could be a persistent annoyance, especially on Israel, and could use the threat of a 2028 primary from a challenger backed by the DSA and New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani as leverage.

More moderate members may attempt to latch onto this antiestablishment energy to pressure Jeffries (see Michigan Senator Elissa Slotkin’s call for new party leadership). His situation would resemble that facing Speaker Mike Johnson’s (R-LA) in the Biden administration, who had limited room to maneuver thanks to a small majority and who faced strong challenges from his ideological extreme. Intra-party divides could become the dominant story in the next Congress, undermining Democratic unity ahead of 2028.

The rise of the DSA wing will matter as much for tactics as for policy. For years, Democrats have been unwilling to embrace the sorts of institutionally-disruptive tactics that have, arguably, made the MAGA movement so successful. That is on course to change. Many incumbent defeats this year have been less ideological than personal; the charge of being a Washington “insider” is an increasingly effective cudgel.

In the Republican Party in the 2010s, antiestablishment energy led to the adoption of brinksmanship tactics by the Tea Party. This same dynamic could take hold among Democrats, with left-wingers agitating against negotiations on government funding or the debt ceiling; recent record-length government shutdowns, spurred by the Democratic base’s demands not to compromise on healthcare subsidies and immigration-enforcement funding, could become a recurring feature of the coming

Congress.

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